

The Hook Lab

100 Scroll-Stopping Hooks for Marketers and Creators

eseneffwork17

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THE HOOK LAB

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Stop guessing. Steal these. Replace [BRACKETS] . Post.

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WHY HOOKS MATTER — The Brutal Math

The first line of your content does **80% of the work**. If it fails, the next 999 words die unread.

Average attention spans on social platforms in 2026:

Platform	Average attention until scroll
TikTok / Reels	1.7 seconds
Twitter/X	2.3 seconds
Instagram feed	2.6 seconds
LinkedIn	3.1 seconds
YouTube thumbnail	1.4 seconds

You have **less than 3 seconds** to earn the next 30. That's the entire job of a hook.

The good news: viral content isn't random. It follows **patterns**. This book contains 100 of those patterns, ready to deploy.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **Find your platform** in the table of contents.
2. **Pick 3-5 hooks** that match your niche or message.
3. **Replace [BRACKETS]** with your specifics.
4. **Post.** Track what works.
5. **Build your own swipe file** of the top 10 that work for *your* audience.

Pro tip: Don't try to use all 100 at once. Pick 3 every Sunday for the week ahead. Master them. Iterate.

SECTION 1 — TWITTER/X HOOKS (25)

*Tweets cap at ~280 chars, but **the hook is the first 80**. That's all most people read before scrolling.*

Curiosity Gap (1-5)

1. The reason 90% of [audience] never [outcome] isn't what you think.
2. I just realized something about [topic] that changes everything I thought I knew.
3. There's a quiet pattern in how the top 1% of [niche] operate. It took me 6 years to see it.
4. Most advice on [topic] is backwards. Here's what actually works:
5. The dumbest mistake I made in [year] cost me \$[amount]. Don't repeat it:

Specific Numbers (6-10)

1. I spent 47 hours testing [thing]. Here are the only 4 things that mattered:
2. 100 days. 1 strategy. \$[result]. Here's exactly what I did:
3. 9 of 10 [audience] are doing [thing] wrong. Here's the fix:
4. From \$[low] to \$[high] in [timeframe]. The 5 plays that moved the needle:
5. I read 23 books on [topic] so you don't have to. Here are the 6 ideas worth keeping:

Contrarian Claims (11-15)

1. Stop trying to [popular advice]. Do this instead:
2. Everyone tells you to [X]. They're wrong. Here's why:
3. The "[buzzword] mindset" is a trap. Here's what works in 2026:
4. Hot take: [counter-intuitive opinion]. Convince me I'm wrong:
5. I disagree with the entire [niche] industry on one thing:

Personal Story / Confession (16-20)

1. In 2024, I quit my \$[salary] job to chase [goal]. Year 1 broke me. Here's what year 2 taught me:
2. I almost gave up at month 8. What changed in month 9:

3. My biggest [niche] failure cost me \$[amount]. I'd pay it again. Here's why:
4. Last year, I made every mistake possible in [niche]. The 7 that hurt the most:
5. I was wrong about [common belief]. Took me [X] years to admit it. Here's the truth:

Actionable Promise (21-25)

1. 5 [things] you can [do] in the next 60 minutes to [outcome]:
 2. The free 12-step framework I wish I had when I started [niche]:
 3. Save this thread. The next time you [scenario], you'll thank me:
 4. If I had to start [niche] over today with \$0, here's exactly what I'd do:
 5. The simple [tool/system/template] that changed my [outcome]. Steal it:
-

SECTION 2 — LINKEDIN HOOKS (25)

*LinkedIn rewards **whitespace** and **personal angle**. Aim for first line under 12 words, then break.*

Pattern Interrupt (26-30)

1. I got fired in February. Best thing that happened to me.
2. Most [job title]s are doing this wrong.
3. Stop networking. Start something.
4. The advice that built my career? Ignore the advice.
5. I just rejected a \$[amount] offer. Here's why.

Specific Outcome / Result (31-35)

1. From 0 to [number] [metric] in [timeframe]. No ads.
2. I closed \$[amount] in [period] without a single sales call.
3. My team shipped 12 features last quarter. Here's the system:
4. We cut customer churn by 47% in 90 days. The 3 changes that worked:
5. I doubled my freelance income while working 50% less. Here's how:

Shocking Stat / Question (36-40)

1. 70% of [audience] will never [outcome]. Here's why most never realize it:
2. What if [common belief] is actually slowing you down?
3. The average [job title] wastes 4.2 hours per week on [thing]. Here's how to recover them:
4. Why is nobody talking about [emerging trend]?
5. Quiet truth: [contrarian statement most won't admit].

Career Wisdom (41-45)

1. The skill that's paid me the most? It's not what you think.
2. 5 lessons from 5 years building [thing]. The one nobody warned me about:
3. After managing 200+ people, here's what actually predicts success:

4. The interview question that tells me everything:
5. Promotion isn't about working harder. It's about [reframe].

Community Building (46-50)

1. Comment "[keyword]" and I'll send you my [resource]. (Free, no pitch.)
 2. I'm hiring [role]. DMs open. Tell me what you'd build:
 3. To anyone considering quitting their job to [goal] — read this first.
 4. Mentorship offer: 5 free 30-min calls this week for [audience]. Reply to claim:
 5. What's the worst [niche] advice you've ever received? I'll start:
-

SECTION 3 — INSTAGRAM REELS & CAPTION HOOKS (25)

*Reels: hook in **first 2 seconds of video** (also paste as caption first line). Captions: scroll-stop with **first 7 words**.*

Bold Promise (51-55)

1. Save 10 hours next week with this:
2. Three things I wish I knew at 20.
3. The tool that doubled my output. Free:
4. POV: you finally fixed [problem].
5. This is your sign to [action]:

Storytelling Lead (56-60)

1. I made \$0 my first 6 months. Then this happened:
2. The day I almost deleted my account. Glad I didn't:
3. Story time how a 3-minute conversation changed my [career/year/life]:
4. Plot twist: I was the problem.
5. Last week, a stranger said something to me that I can't stop thinking about:

Question-Led (61-65)

1. Are you tired of [pain point]?
2. Why does nobody talk about [topic]?
3. What if you only need 1 [thing] to [outcome]?
4. Could AI replace your job? Here's the honest answer:
5. Why did I quit my \$[salary] job? Three reasons:

Numbered Lists (66-70)

1. 5 signs you're closer than you think:

2. 7 [things] every [audience] should own:
3. 3 mistakes I'll never make again:
4. 4 books that quietly changed my [year/career/business]:
5. 10 underrated [tools/habits/skills] for [audience]:

Trend-Riding (71-75)

1. The [recent trend] is breaking my brain in the best way.
 2. AI just changed [niche] forever. Here's what it means for you:
 3. If you're not using [emerging tool], you're already behind.
 4. Why everyone is suddenly talking about [X]:
 5. The next 12 months will reward [skill]. Here's why:
-

SECTION 4 — TIKTOK & YOUTUBE

SHORTS HOOKS (25)

*TikTok: spoken hook in **first 1.5 seconds**. Often paired with on-screen text. Shorts: title + thumbnail + first 1 second = 3 simultaneous hooks.*

Visual + Verbal Combo (76-80)

1. "If you only watch one thing today, watch this." [hold up object]
2. "Three secrets [niche] gurus won't tell you." [count on fingers]
3. "I made \$[amount] last month with this." [show screen]
4. "Stop. You're doing [thing] wrong." [direct camera]
5. "POV: it's 11 PM and you finally figured out [problem]." [scene shot]

Direct Challenge (81-85)

1. "Everyone says [X]. They're lying. Here's the truth:"
2. "If you do this one thing for 30 days, I promise [outcome]."
3. "I dare you to try this for a week."
4. "This is the easiest [outcome] tutorial on TikTok. 30 seconds."
5. "Tell me you're a [audience] without telling me. I'll go first:"

Hook + Payoff (86-90)

1. "The [tool/method] that saves me 5 hours every week. Free:"
2. "Why my [thing] grew 10x faster than everyone else's:"
3. "How to write a [thing] that converts. Step 1:"
4. "I tested [N] [methods]. Only 1 actually worked."
5. "The exact prompt that gives me [outcome]. Save this:"

Voice-Driven Curiosity (91-95)

1. "There's a thing nobody is talking about in [niche]..."

2. "I just discovered something nobody mentions about [topic]."
3. "Quiet quitting is dead. The new thing is [trend]."
4. "If your [metric] is below [number], please watch this."
5. "I'm about to lose followers for saying this, but:"

Educational Snap (96-100)

1. "Three minutes. One framework. Endless [outcome]."
 2. "The 4 question framework that [outcome]:"
 3. "Bookmark this. You'll need it later."
 4. "If you only learn one thing about [niche], let it be this:"
 5. "This is why your [thing] isn't working. And how to fix it in 60 seconds."
-

BONUS — THE 7 MASTER HOOK FORMULAS

Every hook in this book maps to one of these 7 patterns. Master them, and you can write hooks forever.

1. The Curiosity Gap

Open a loop the brain must close. - Template: "The reason [X] never [Y] isn't what you think." - Why it works: triggers compulsive completion bias.

2. The Specific Number

Specific numbers feel real. Round numbers feel made up. - Template: "I tried [number] [things]. Only [smaller number] worked." - Why it works: specificity = credibility.

3. The Contrarian Claim

Bold opposite of common wisdom = pattern interrupt. - Template: "Everyone says [popular advice]. They're wrong. Here's why:" - Why it works: the brain pauses to resolve conflict.

4. The Personal Confession

Vulnerability + story = trust. - Template: "I [embarrassing or expensive thing]. Here's what I learned:" - Why it works: humans bond over honest mistakes.

5. The Specific Outcome

Show the destination so they want to learn the journey. - Template: "From [low state] to [high state] in [time]. Here's how:" - Why it works: aspiration triggers attention.

6. The Question Hook

A sharp question forces the brain to engage. - Template: "What if [common belief] is actually [opposite]?" - Why it works: questions are open loops the brain wants to close.

7. The Save-This Promise

Position your content as a future-self resource. - Template: "Save this. You'll need it later." - Why it works: utility framing increases bookmarks + replays.

BONUS — 7 COMMON MISTAKES THAT KILL HOOKS

1. **Starting with greeting fluff.** "Hey guys, what's up!" instant scroll. Cut it.
 2. **Burying the lead.** If your insight is in line 5, line 1 better be a hook for line 5.
 3. **Vague generalities.** "Some thoughts on success" forgettable. "Why I quit at month 8" unforgettable.
 4. **Claiming everything is "the truth".** If everything is the truth nothing is. Save it for your strongest takes.
 5. **Starting every hook with "I".** Audience-first beats author-first. "You're doing X wrong" > "I do X this way."
 6. **Using AI-generated buzzwords.** "Game-changer", "unlock", "level up" — AI smell. Use plain English.
 7. **Posting and forgetting.** Hook A/B testing is everything. Same content, 5 different hooks, see which earns the next 30 seconds.
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CLOSING

Hooks are the **most leveraged sentence in your business**. A good hook on the wrong content still gets 10x reach. A bad hook on great content dies in 2 seconds.

You now have 100 of them. Pick 3 this week. Master them. Track results. Build your own version 2.0 from the 10 that work for *your* audience.

The internet rewards specificity, vulnerability, and bold claims — in that order. Don't be vague. Don't pretend. Don't be afraid to be wrong.

Stop scrolling. Start hooking.

— esenefwork17

APPENDIX — Hook Tracking Template

Hook used	Platform	Date	Impressions	Engagement %	Verdict
#14	Twitter	Mon	12,400	3.4%	keep
#62	LinkedIn	Tue	4,200	1.8%	retire
#87	TikTok	Wed	28,000	6.1%	winner

Track every hook you use for 30 days. The winners become your personal swipe file. The losers teach you what your audience doesn't care about. Both are valuable.

END OF BOOK

Version 1.0 · 2026 · For 100 more hooks, see the upcoming Hook Lab Vol. 2 — sign up at the closing of *The AI Solopreneur OS*.